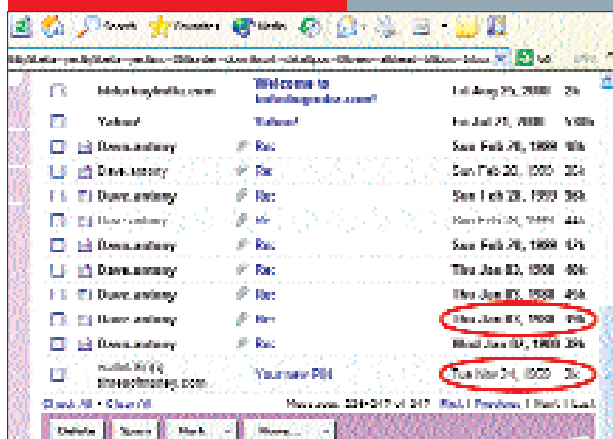


DigiPick of the month

"Spam Is Old
News"



Last month's
winner is

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**Pro C# 2005 and the .NET
2.0 Platform**
by Andrew Troelsen
Distributed by
Dreamtech Press



WIN!

Send in your entry and you could win an exciting gift just by sharing an amusing picture with a tech angle to it. The picture should have been shot by you, and should not have been published anywhere earlier. E-mail your picture with the subject **"DigiPick"** and your postal address **on or before the 20th of this month to digipick@thinkdigit.com**. One prize-winning picture will be published each month.

Rs 13,250). So you could actually go out and get 42-inch LCDs for a fraction of their price if you were buying it online. Woolworths soon realized the mistake, and the correct prices returned all too quickly. However, in that time quite a few Christmas shoppers had already placed their orders. The retailer was forced to issue formal apologies to the frustrated buyers, informing them of the error and reversing their payments—thereby not honouring the sale.

In similar fashion, UK toy retailer Hamleys sold out almost their entire online stock recently. The surge in purchasing was due to a glitch in their system. Basically, Hamleys offer discount vouchers, which contain a code which you can apply to avail of a discount. Now some Web programmer overlooked the fact that buyers might

"accidentally" enter the same discount code more than once, thus multiplying the discount offered. It didn't take long for the glitch to be found though, and people flocked to the site to avail of as much as 60 per cent overall discounts. There were stories going around of buyers boasting of saving thousands of pounds while Christmas e-shopping! Some of the online spectators described the events on the day as Vikings visiting Hamleys, claiming that the site had been pillaged. Apparently, almost everything popular was sold out, or out of stock.

However, Hamleys' troubles were just beginning—they don't distinguish between online and offline stocks, and have one common warehouse for both. This meant that everything they had in stock had been sold to online buyers, and neither online

nor offline buyers would be able to purchase or order anything until they replenished their warehouse. Although the site was fixed up pretty quickly, Hamleys' initial knee-jerk reaction was to state that they would honour all sales. Saner heads seemed to have prevailed in the boardroom, however, because they soon retracted that statement, probably after a few accountants worked overtime to estimate the losses!

The store later mailed every buyer, telling them that their money had been returned, and offered them a generous (yet sane) discount of 25 per cent on the next purchase.

We, however, are left wondering whether Web programmers at the companies are getting fired, or whether some business executive is being patted on the back!

To elucidate, how can we be sure that this was a programming glitch, and not a weird and aggressive marketing tactic? It *did* get them into the news, and had thousands of buyers (read actual people with money) register and provide their contact information! Does this mean that we're going to see many more "glitches" on e-commerce sites? Maybe this will start a new trend, where programmers who make mistakes will be sought after! What's sad is that none of the buyers seem to have got their "highly discounted" products, and the retail stores are laughing all the way to the bank, with people just giving in and accepting the consolation discounts!

People Who Changed Computing

The Discman!

The CDs and DVDs we so wantonly use and throw today wouldn't have even been possible had it not



James T Russell

been for the mind of James T Russell. He started off with his inventions at the age of six, when he

crafted himself a remote-controlled battleship, complete with a chamber for his lunch. After his B.A. in Physics, he worked as a physicist with General Electric, and was one of the first people in the world to use a colour TV and a keyboard with a computer.

Frustrated with the way his vinyl records were degenerating, he wanted to work on a system where audio could be read without any physical contact between the moving parts. The best way, he figured, would be if he represented the binary 0 and 1 as intensities of light—dark and bright respectively. Furthermore, by squeezing more dark and light areas into the same space, he saw that he could store huge amounts of music on a piece of film.

His work on optical data storage began in the Bettelle Memorial Institute, where he worked as a Senior Scientist, and he constructed his first prototype of a digital optical recording system. Data was recorded on a photo-sensitive platter, which became the first CD-ROM. The idea evolved through the 70s, but with few takers at first. Eventually, though, audio companies realised the obvious benefits, and the rest is history.